Planning backwards from what students need to learn

Use this when a lesson contains worthwhile activities but the knowledge students should leave with is unclear. Start with the intended learning, then select the explanation, practice and checks that will build it.

How to do it well

1 Specify the endpoint. Describe what students will know or do independently, including the quality of explanation or performance required.

2 Unpack the demand. List the prerequisite knowledge and genuinely new components; identify which missing component would prevent success.

3 Plan the route. Sequence a clear model, supported rehearsal, accurate independent practice and a purposeful variation.

4 Plan decision points. Select questions that will reveal whether students are ready for each increase in demand, with a likely response to common errors.

5 Prepare the resources last. Keep only material that supports the route, and schedule later opportunities to retrieve and apply the learning.

What this sounds like

“By the end of this sequence, you will explain which material is suitable and justify your choice using its properties.”

Classroom example. In History, the endpoint is an explanation of why one factor contributed to an event. Planning begins with the expected causal reasoning and evidence. The teacher identifies the factual knowledge students need, models a causal paragraph, checks the link between claim and evidence, then sets a different factor for practice. The worksheet follows that sequence rather than determining it.

Top tips that make the technique work

Write the final response first. An exemplar exposes the vocabulary, reasoning and component knowledge students will need.

Plan the learning episode. A new idea may need part of a lesson or several lessons; the timetable is not the learning sequence.

Plan the check alongside the task. Decide what a successful response would demonstrate before choosing slides or worksheets.

Keep useful difficulty. Remove logistical obstacles without removing the thinking needed to reach the endpoint.

Plan beyond first success. Build in later retrieval and a less familiar application so today’s performance is revisited.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Align the question, explanation and practice with the same learning.	Planning an activity sequence before defining the learning.
Change the route when a prerequisite is insecure.	Treating a completed product as evidence that every component is understood.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation. Some links support part of this guide rather than the whole technique.

Barton - Planning a Learning Episode | Barton Lesson planning